

29, The Crucial Position of Feudal Society in the Developmental Process of Human History

Thus far, we have completed our brief examination of the developmental trajectory of human society.

Beginning in 1500 AD, the relatively independent historical developmental processes across various global regions concluded. Western nations, which were the first to march toward early modern and modern civilization (近现代文明), began exerting an increasingly intense influence upon non-Western nations. Consequently, attempting to distinctly categorize the nature of a specific regime—as was possible prior to the Age of Discovery (地理大发现)—becomes exceedingly difficult. However, readers reaching this point will not find it difficult to discern that what Europeans term the "Middle Ages" (中世纪)—namely, the historical epoch in which **feudal society** (封建社会) existed—is genuinely the bifurcation point determining the destiny of a nation and a people.

The modern civilization created by the Western world today is founded precisely upon the series of ideologies, cultures, concepts, organizations, and institutions generated throughout the entire process of **feudal society** from its inception to its conclusion. The dark ages during the initial phase of **feudalization** (封建化) were not genuine darkness, but rather the necessary preparations executed for societal reconstruction; the adage "there can be no construction without destruction" (“不破不立”) encapsulates precisely this meaning.

Several millennia had elapsed from the genesis of human civilization to the establishment of the world's first **feudal regime** (封建政权). When the **feudal economic system** (封建经济制度) emerged upon a piece of land, the civilization there had already weathered thousands of years of time. People had created religions, constructed city-states, formed countries, organized governments, and possessed armies. Humanity pioneered eras of prosperity; from the perspective of the empire's inhabitants, any land characterized by lofty crowns and broad belts (峨冠博带 / *representing civilized elites*) was bathed in the radiance of classical civilization (古典文明).

Yet, it was precisely beneath those magnificent monuments and amid that blinding radiance that every single human individual appeared profoundly more minuscule. Exactly when human beings were contented with the augmentation of their capacity to comprehend and alter nature, they found it exceedingly difficult to realize that they had simultaneously acquired another capacity: the capacity for self-destruction. The astonishing bureaucratic system (官僚体制) lorded over every subject of the empire brimming with contempt; day after day, it devoured the wealth created by society, yet generated increasingly shriveling value.

Feudalization constituted the turning point of human history. Prior to its occurrence, the regimes ruling the inhabitants of every civilized world were perpetually becoming increasingly colossal and labyrinthine, while the **community** (共同体) intimately sharing the joys and sorrows of the individual was continuously shrinking—from tribes (部落), to large extended families, down to minuscule nuclear families. The consequences are blindingly obvious if this trend, which inevitably leads to the neglect of individual freedom and rights, were to continue; we have already witnessed this exact consequence in China.

Yet the sheer serendipity of history lies in the fact that when the **productive forces** (生产力) developed to a certain threshold, small-scale production and the **natural economy** (自然经济) could

become the absolute mainstream relying upon their efficiency advantages. Consequently, all the massive empires crumbled into dust under the devastating blow of the feudal economy. Human society genuinely gained the possibility of marching toward modern civilization because, during the societal reconstruction subsequent to **feudalization**, the communities surrounding every individual did not continue to shrink alongside the augmentation of state power—in fact, it was physically impossible for them to shrink any further. Instead, they were now growing in tandem.

It was only at this precise juncture that people acquired sufficient strength capable of defending the knowledge they had learned throughout the long Middle Ages—knowledge utterly unheard of and inconceivable to their predecessors—and, most crucially, human dignity and value.

Recalling the distinction between the two social transitions of the **classical era** (古典时代) and the **early modern period** (近世) naturally enables one to comprehend the profound significance of **feudalization**. When the **despotic power** (专制权力) of monarchs augmented during the **classical period** (古典时期), people were virtually helpless against it; however, when the monarchs of early modern absolutist states (绝对主义国家) attempted to declare "*L'État, c'est moi*" (“朕即国家” / *I am the state*), the Scientific Revolution (科学革命) and the Enlightenment (思想启蒙) were already simultaneously underway.

Although it is deeply regrettable that my motherland did not undergo these processes, I have heard such extraordinary sagas from those nations that won their revolutions along the way; it is undeniably a hymn to human courage.

This is identically why I am rather reluctant to discuss the history subsequent to the conclusion of the Middle Ages. Not merely because the saga of the modern and contemporary eras is genuinely too distant for the Chinese people, but also because it is exceedingly difficult to discern their decisive role regarding the developmental process of human history.

Reflect upon this, my friends: according to the methodology and conclusions we have deduced all the way to this point, has this world undergone any quintessential mutations from 700 years ago to the present day? No. The factual reality is that if we examine the various regimes existing in the world in 1325, we practically already know exactly what position their development occupies in the world today.

England was the region where the **feudal system** (封建制度) was most developed; by 1325, it conspicuously occupied the foremost vanguard globally in the **feudalization** (封建化) process, already poised to depart from **feudal society** (封建社会). France could be deemed the cradle of the **feudal system**, occupying a position strictly second only to England in the **feudalization** process. The various regimes of Western and Central Europe did not advance as rapidly as England and France, yet the **feudal system** had identically been firmly established. Northern Europe caught the final train of **feudalization**. The **feudalization** of Eastern Europe was inevitably subjected to the impact of myriad interfering factors.

Byzantium (拜占庭) was merely lingering in its death throes, while the **Near East** (近东), which had once served as the epicenter of civilization, had irrecoverably missed the temporal window for **feudalization**. Iran was groaning beneath the iron hooves of conquerors, and this was merely a prologue. India had indeed **feudalized** to a certain extent, but the factors obstructing its **feudalization** process had all manifested, and none could be resolved in the short term. Ethiopia and China's Tibet had identically commenced **feudalization**, but their impoverished **productive**

forces (生产力) rendered it phenomenally difficult for wealth to be effectively utilized for investment at scale.

China had long since embarked upon a dead end, and was furthermore hurtling down it at an accelerating pace.

Although Japan's **feudalization** process lagged behind Europe's, it had already forged an unstoppable momentum. The **feudal system** of the Indochinese Peninsula was in the midst of formation, yet the difficulties encountered by India would identically be encountered here. Moreover, **feudalization** commenced far too late across the vast majority of the Indochinese Peninsula; its natural evolution would shortly be violently interrupted by Western influence. The Koreans erroneously adopted the institutions of the **restoration-bureaucratic period** (复辟官僚时期) during the **classical era** (古典时代), and they were imminently about to pay the ultimate price for this. Although Vietnam achieved independence from China, it identically inherited the toxic baggage of the Tang Empire, rendering it exceedingly difficult to embark again upon a normal path of **feudalization**.

Maritime Southeast Asia was still too backward; the **feudal system** was as yet fundamentally untraceable here. West Africa, benefiting from the trans-Saharan trade, surprisingly manifested the facade of a **classical society** (古典社会); however, even if this was not an ephemeral mirage, chronologically speaking, it was already fatally late. The East African coast identically could not even touch the periphery of **feudalization**.

Upon the expansive steppes of the Eurasian continent, nomadic regimes fundamentally lacked any conditions to actualize **feudalization**. As for the New World, although it remained isolated from the Old World, considering Europe's progressively sophisticated nautical technologies alongside the transformative mutations emerging in the Late Middle Ages, what rationale is there to believe that the monumental enterprise of connecting the world together would not commence from Europe?

I maintain that this is a phenomenally astonishing reality: in truth, over the past 700 years, the positional shifts of the various regions of the Old World within the **historical sequence** (历史序列) of development have been exceedingly limited.

If we rewind another 700 years from 1325, then attempting to accurately predict the global situation of 1325 AD from the circumstances of 625 AD would not be so effortless; numerous paramount pieces of information had, after all, not yet manifested. If we rewind yet another 700 years from 625 AD, we would find it virtually impossible to deduce roughly what state the various nations of the world were in during 625 BC [*sic; logically referring to 625 AD being predicted from 76 BC*] based on the circumstances of 76 BC.

I contend that, quintessentially, there have been merely two processes thus far that triggered colossal mutations in the epicenter of human civilization, thereby precipitating the permutation of the rankings (*from advanced to backward*) among various regions within the historical process. The first was **The Great Expansion** (大扩张) prior to the genesis of classical empires; the second was precisely **feudalization** following the collapse of classical empires. The Age of Discovery (地理大发现) was merely the victors of the feudal revolution savoring the fruits of their triumph.

In a word, provided we perceive the prior historical trajectory of a colony—which inherited the social developmental stage of its mother country—as identical to that of its mother country, then the

success or failure of **feudalization** possesses decisive significance in the history of any region up to the present day. Consequently, I phenomenally endorse the formulation of the "Middle Ages"; it is arguably the most profoundly insightful nomenclature I know across all human academic disciplines. The feudal Middle Ages undeniably occupy the absolute central position within the entirety of human history.

29, 封建社会在人类历史发展进程中的关键地位

到此为止我们就完成了对于人类社会发展历程的简要考察，从公元 1500 年开始，世界各地相对独立的历史发展进程结束了，最先走向近现代文明的西方国家开始对非西方国家施加越来越强烈的影响，想要像地理大发现之前那样清晰的划分出某个政权的性质就会更加困难。然而，读者看到这里已经不难发现欧洲人所谓的“中世纪”，也就是封建社会所存在的历史时期，实在是决定一个国家和民族命运的分叉口。今天西方世界所创造的现代文明就建立在封建社会从始到终的进程所产生的一系列思想、文化、观念、组织和制度上。封建化初期的黑暗年代并不是真正的黑暗，而是为社会重构而做出的必要准备，所谓“不破不立”正是此意。人类文明从诞生到世界上第一个封建政权建立已经经过了几千年，当封建经济制度出现在一片土地上时，这里的文明已经经历了上千年的时光。人们创造了宗教，建设了城邦，形成了国家，组织起政府，拥有了军队。人们开创了繁荣的时代，在帝国的居民看来，凡是峨冠博带之地都沐浴在古典文明的光辉下。可就是在宏伟的纪念碑下，耀眼的光芒中，每一个人类个体显得更加渺小。就在人类满足于自己认识和改变自然的能力增长之时，他们难以意识到自己同样获得了另一种能力，那就是自我毁灭的能力。令人惊叹的官僚体制充满蔑视地凌驾在每一个帝国的子民头上，它日复一日地吞噬着社会创造出的财富，却产生着日渐萎缩的价值。

封建化是人类历史的转折点，在它发生之前，统治每一个文明世界居民的政权一直在变得越来越庞大和复杂，而与个人休戚与共的共同体却越来越小，从部落，到大家族，直到小家庭。这样必然导致忽视个体自由和权利的趋势如果继续下去其后果显而易见，我们已经在中国看到了这种后果。可世事巧就巧在当生产力发展到一定水平时，小生产和自然经济凭借其效率优势能够成为绝对主流，所有的大帝国都在封建经济的打击下土崩瓦解了。人类的社会真正可能走向现代文明，因为在封建化之后的社会重组中，每个人身边的共同体不是随着国家力量的增强而继续缩小，实际上也不可能再缩小了，现在它们在一同增长。也只有在这个时候，人们才有了足够的力量能够捍卫他们在漫长中世纪中所学到的，前人闻所未闻，想也不敢想的知识，最重要的是人的尊严和价值。回忆一下古典时代和近世两次社会过渡的不同自然能够理解封建化的意义，当古典时期君主的专制权力增长时，人们几乎对此束手无策；但是当近世绝对主义国家的君主试图宣布“朕即国家”时，科学革命和思想启蒙就同时在进行了。虽然很遗憾我的祖国没有经历这些，但是我从那些一路赢得革命胜利的国家听说了这样非同凡响的故事，的确是人类勇气的赞歌。

这也是为什么我不太愿意讨论中世纪结束之后的历史，不仅仅是因为近现代的故事离中国人实在太遥远，而且它们对于人类历史进程来说又很难看出其决定性作用。想一想吧，朋友们，按照我们之前一路推理到现在的方法和结论，这个世界从 700 年前至今发生过什么本质的变化吗？没有。事实就是，如果我们看 1325 年的世界上存在的各个政权，那么我们几乎已经知道他们在今天的发展处于世界的什么位置。英格兰是封建制度最发达的地区，到 1325 年它在封建进程中显然处于世界最前方的位置，已经准备离开封建社会了。法国可谓封建制度的故乡，在封建进程中处于仅次于英国的位置。西欧和中欧的各个政权没有英法走得那么快，但是封建制度也已经稳固建立起来。北欧赶上了封建化的末班车。东欧的封建化必然要遭到各种干扰因素的影响。拜占庭不过苟延残喘，曾经作为文明中心的近东已经错过了封建化的时机。伊朗正在征服者的铁蹄下呻吟，而且这还只是一个开始。印度确实一定程度封建化了，但是阻碍其封建进程的因素都已经显现，而且短期内均无法解决。埃塞俄比亚和中国西藏也开始封建化了，但是贫瘠的生产力使得财富难以成规模有效地用于投资。中国早已走上死路，而且还在加速狂奔。日本封建化进程虽然落后于欧洲，但是已经形成了不可阻挡的态势。中南半岛的封建制度正在形成中，但是印度遇到的困难这里也会遇到。而且中南半岛大部分地区封建化开始的太晚，其自然演进不久就会被西方影响所打断。朝鲜人错误地在古典时代采取了复辟官僚时期的体制，他们马上就要为此付出代价。越南虽从中国独立，可是同样继承了唐帝国的包袱，难以再走上正常的封建化道路。东南亚海岛还太过落后，封建制度在这里尚且难以寻觅。西非得益于跨撒哈拉贸易居然出现了古典社会的样子，可是即使这

不是镜花水月，从时间上看也晚矣。东非沿海同样连封建化的边都挨不上。在欧亚大陆面积广阔的大草原上，游牧政权还不具备任何实现封建化的条件。至于新大陆，虽然仍然与旧大陆相隔绝，但是考虑到欧洲日益精进的航海技术以及中世纪晚期出现的变革，有什么理由认为将世界连接在一起的事业不会从欧洲开始呢？

我认为这是非常惊人的事实，实际上 700 年来旧大陆各个地区在历史发展序列上的位置变动非常有限。如果从 1325 年再往前倒退 700 年，那么从公元 625 年世界的情况我们想要准确预测公元 1325 年的情况就没有那么容易，很多重要信息毕竟还没有显现出来。如果从公元 625 年再倒退 700 年，我们就几乎无法从公元前 76 年的情况推测公元前 625 年世界各个国家大致处于一种怎样的状态了。我认为从本质而言，迄今为止使得人类文明的中心发生巨大变化，从而导致各个地区在历史进程中排名（从先进到落后）发生转换的过程无非有两个，第一个是古典帝国产生前的大扩张，第二个就是古典帝国崩溃后的封建化。地理大发现也不过是封建革命的胜利者品尝胜利的果实罢了。一言以蔽之，只要我们视继承了母国社会发展阶段的殖民地此前的历史进程与母国相同，那么封建化的成败在任何一个地区迄今为止的历史中都具有决定性意义。因此我非常赞同“中世纪”这个提法，这可以说是我知道的人类各个学科中最具有真知灼见的命名了，封建的中世纪的确在人类的整个历史中具有中心的位置。